

Negotiating the Price of a Car

9 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

For anyone about to name or answer a price on something big like a car, half convinced that going quiet just means they don't know how to do this, when it's **the discomfort of the pushback they're avoiding**.

THE GOAL

You're trying to land on a number close to what this car is worth to you, without the moment itself talking you into paying more than that.

CHECKLIST

The moment a price is first named between you and the seller, whether they ask what you'd pay or just state a number.

- ☐ If they ask what you'd pay before naming their own price, ask what they're asking for the car instead.
- ☐ Once a number is out, whether yours or theirs, write down a few different amounts you could counter with.
- ☐ When it's your turn to counter, name a precise figure instead of a rounded number.
- ☐ Say your counter, then **stop talking**; let them speak next, however long the pause runs.
- ☐ If you catch yourself about to soften the number with an apology, cut the apology and keep the number.
- ☐ If they hold the same number twice in a row with no movement, treat that as their real limit, not an opening move.
- ☐ If they step away to check with someone else, decide before they're back whether your last number still stands.
- ☐ Decide right then whether you're satisfied or want one more round, using the top figure you set beforehand as the line.
- ☐ If you decide to accept, **say the agreed number back** to them before anything else gets discussed.
- ☐ Once you accept, write the exact number down, on paper or in the message thread, before any paperwork starts.
- ☐ If you decide to stop instead, say one line plainly: "I need to think it over," then stop talking.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Going quiet and taking their price isn't about not knowing what to do.
- 2 Whoever names a price first usually **sets the number both sides circle**, so say yours.
- 3 People hiding what they want in a negotiation believe it shows more than it does.

What's behind going quiet

KNOW

Going quiet and taking their price isn't about not knowing what to do.

Pushing back can feel like starting a fight, and dodging that discomfort, not a lack of skill, is what stops people. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

You're not the only person who lets a price slide by without pushing.

Across five studies, about 19 in 20 people skipped negotiating in at least half the chances they had to. [Source 2](#)

DO

A couple of percent off can still be real money on something this size.

On average, people needed a discount worth a fifth to more than a third of the price before it felt worth pushing for at all. [Source 2](#)

What the numbers you hear and say are doing

DON'T

Whoever names a price first usually **sets the number both sides circle**, so say yours.

People judge an unfamiliar price by whatever number they hear first, even a made-up or extreme figure, so staying quiet gives away that edge. [Source 3](#)

DO

A specific counter, ending in an odd digit, pulls harder than a round number.

Once negotiating is underway, a precise number signals a worked-out value, while round numbers read as a rough guess. [Source 3](#)

DO

You can picture several possible counters, not just the number someone else named.

Picturing several different counters loosens a first number's grip on what you say next, instead of narrowing straight to a single reply. [Source 4](#)

What you don't have to manage about how you come across

KNOW

People hiding what they want in a negotiation believe it shows more than it does.

Even experienced negotiators overestimated how much of what they tried to hide came through to their counterpart. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Firm wording beats warm wording when you negotiate.

Firm wording pulled stronger counteroffers in both a real negotiation and a lab negotiation, with no drop in the other side's reported satisfaction. [Source 6](#)

DON'T

Breakthroughs in a negotiation often come right after a silent pause.

Staying quiet for a moment after you name your number doesn't cost you anything, and the other side rated it no worse. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you get the price down to the dealer's invoice price, they're barely making anything on the sale.

ACTUALLY

Manufacturers pay a chunk of that invoice price back to the dealer later as **holdback**, so a deal at invoice can still leave real profit on the table. [Source 8](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/conflict-resolution/power-in-negotiation-examples-of-being-overly-committed-to-the-deal/>
2. <https://blog.kelley.indianapolis.iu.edu/2025/12/16/why-many-americans-avoid-negotiating-even-when-it-costs-them/>
3. <https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/negotiation-skills-daily/anchoring-for-maximum-effect-nb/>
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5. <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1023/A:1023693700484>
6. https://www.mikeyeomans.info/papers/communicating_warmth.pdf
7. <https://mitsloan.mit.edu/ideas-made-to-matter/negotiation-use-silence-to-improve-outcomes-all>
8. <https://www.edmunds.com/car-buying/dealer-holdback/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Big purchases at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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